grizzled hero of Panipat, what to do.

Many agreed with him. Abdullah the Uzbek, whom Akbar had chased out of Malwa, returned from Gujarat and joined Ali Quli. Asaf Khan, too, having hidden 'like a wild beast . . . in the forests'[53] for a while, decided to take his chance with the Uzbeks – as did a new posse of insurgents, known to history as the Mirzas: Timurid princes chafing at Akbar's increasing authority. Ali Quli's Jaunpur, as a modern historian puts it, 'was fast becoming a rendezvous of disgruntled elements'.[54]

Unfortunately for him, Ali Quli had remarkable spirit for insurrection but little talent for binding men to his cause.

At their very first meeting, Asaf Khan was put off by the Uzbeks' arrogance and 'did not like their company'. His dismay only increased, presumably, when he saw Ali Quli 'cast eyes . . . on his property'. Asaf Khan plotted an escape, losing a finger and the tip of his nose in the process, and returned, sheepishly, to Akbar's fold. As for the Mirzas, their alliance with the Uzbeks was equally short-lived, 'for every one in his folly wanted to rule',[55] a desire that does not make for lasting unions. The Mirzas, like Asaf Khan, soon left.

This didn't worry Ali Quli overly; in fact, it seems to have spurred him and his kin to set their sights on a far more ambitious coalition. Not for them Asaf Khan's Gond gold, nor the Mirzas' proud disaffection. The question was no longer of fighting Akbar's authority, but of denouncing it entirely. Akbar was not, after all, the only one of Humayun's descendants with a claim to Humayun's throne.

The ghostly Abul Qasim, Akbar's cousin, might be no more, but what about Humayun's other son, Akbar's half-brother, tucked away in Kabul?

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In March 1567, almost exactly a year after he left Jaunpur, Akbar held a most magnificent – and outrageous – hunt on the outskirts of Lahore.

The hunt was of the '*qamargah*' style, in which beaters encircled a large area of forest land and closed in, thus increasing the density of animal life within their circumference. In this case, several thousand soldiers had been enlisted to enclose an area of over 20 square kilometres – 'from near the mountains on the one side, and from the river [Jhelum] on the other'. For a